

A \$17-million bet brought ChatGPT to CSU campuses. A year later, AI distrust leaves many divided

California State University faces mixed adoption, skepticism, and a demand for AI training.

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Source: https://www.yahoo.com/news/articles/csu-made-17-million-ai-100000999.html?guccounter=1&guce:_referrer=aHR0cHM6Ly93d3cuZ29vZ2xlmNvbS8&guce:_referrer_sig=AQAAAJqSQmp-L-gsZd7Ny6PNb8mfvuZ8u_HClzYd6b1YsCudcoe-rUR1Qyt9G6TytaKPOw7hdeH_3K0qHloc8tTZWZ4Xfm71X5GajKfBjmC-RzfVCGjuD6a9nQcmM9nh1mHD b9tcTW_13lu5D58KPoZi4EDBNa7ISsBXurdCEM55Ryj6

Overview

California State University's controversial \$17-million deal to provide ChatGPT to every campus has produced mixed results: uneven use, distrust of AI-generated content, and fears about job security, even while many respondents say AI tools will be essential in their professions.

The findings come from what is described as the largest AI-in-higher-education study to date, polling 94,000 students, faculty, and staff across 22 CSU campuses.

The survey indicates that nearly every respondent has used AI at least once, with personal use more common than direct educational use.

AI in the Crosshairs

CSU's 18-month contract with OpenAI to license ChatGPT for 460,000 students and 63,000 faculty and staff expires in July.

A petition with over 3,300 signatures is calling for an end to the partnership, while other universities continue adopting similar arrangements.

CSU officials say they are considering options to continue access to AI tools, resources, and training.

How Students Use AI

The survey was not limited to ChatGPT, but respondents identified it as the most-used tool; Gemini and Canva also ranked highly, and Grammarly was especially popular among students.

A majority of students said they would not submit AI-generated work as their own, and roughly nine in ten students said AI outputs should be checked by humans for accuracy.

Students reported both responsible and irresponsible use among peers, and concerns were raised about false positives from AI-detection tools.

Faculty Divisions

Staff generally view AI most favorably, while faculty report both substantial positive and negative effects on teaching and research.

Some faculty have redesigned assignments to reduce misuse, including more in-class assessment and alternative project formats.

Others encourage selective use: keep human control over the parts of teaching and scholarship educators value most, and use AI support where it removes low-value friction.

Broader Tension

The article frames AI in education as neither pure hype nor pure doom. Instead, campuses are negotiating practical trade-offs around integrity, pedagogy, and labor expectations.

A recurring theme is that higher education may need to teach not only AI literacy, but also students' ability to retain attention, judgment, and independent thought in environments that make cognitive outsourcing easy.

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